

In y[our] best interests

THERE'S A WIDE DIVIDE between consumer and corporate interests. The latter is what all major tech companies do and the former is what they claim to do. There's nothing new about this adage. It's been like this ever since the caveman Bob came up with the phrase "customer satisfaction guaranteed" to swindle caveman Rob out of his 13 pebbles and 2 shells. While there are regulations to keep big corporates in check, it shouldn't be forgotten that the smartest minds on the planet work for these companies and not for the Government. So if there's a way to get around regulations, then they're probably going to do it.

It's ridiculously simple to see through their veiled attempts to be helpful. The most recent example would be of Facebook which recently started showing an option labelled "Protect" in their main iOS app. Tapping on the Protect option takes users to an app listing for "Onavo Protect - VPN Security". The average Face-booker who's aware of VPNs will see this as a neat feature since Onavo is a free service. Isn't it so nice of Facebook to help more users on its platform to install a VPN app to secure their internet traffic. That's good guy Facebook right there, except for a few details that aren't so openly advertised.

For starters, Onavo is a data analytics company that was acquired by Facebook in 2013. It even collects your mobile data traffic in order to analyse all that data. After all, they are a data company. Here's the good part, a VPN on your phone generally works by channeling all data packets via their DNS servers. This allows them full access to the device's internet connection. So aside from Facebook already knowing your actions on their platform, they can even get every single information about each and every app you have installed on your phone. This is the price you pay for the "free VPN" service that they've so graciously made available. The information Facebook can get this way allows them to gain insights that only ISPs and governments can. That's how powerful this VPN approach is. They can easily figure out which services are gaining traction in which markets and acquire them. It's like hav-

ing a crystal ball that's eerily accurate about every person on the planet.

It's not just Facebook, every tech company does something equally scummy. Kumail Nanjiani, the actor from Silicon Valley created quite a furore last November when he tweeted about his experiences while visiting tech companies in the San Francisco valley for the show's research. He mentioned how they had zero considerations for ethics while working on building the next big thing. It's understandable how and why tech companies operate in such a manner, ethics are seen as a hindrance. The usual excuse is that they just build the technology, how people use it is out of their control. Just the same way that AI libraries are used to build smarter botnets while the entire IoT infrastructure has barely any security baked in, and how guns are just devices built to protect, but if they were to fall in the bad hands, then there's no stopping the killings. It stands without question that AI libraries wouldn't have grown to this level if there had been tighter regulations around what can and cannot be done.

I used to be in the minority up until a couple of years back as I bothered to read up about a new software before I used it. Or ran it in a sandbox before installing it for good on my PC. Thankfully, more people are now aware about trying something new. Especially, when that new thing is built to "protect" you for absolutely "zero" cost. No thank you, sir. I'd rather pay for my VPN service and get a provider that maintains no logs and gives a middle finger to companies that seek to peek at user data. If you care about your privacy, you should do the same. 



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